

Application of Foundation Model and Agile Modeling to Passive Acoustic Detection of Orcas in Monterey Bay National Marine Sanctuary

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1. Introduction

Monterey Bay Marine National Sanctuary (MBNMS) is an important habitat for three ecotypes of killer whales (orcas, *Orcinus orca*). Transient (Bigg's) orcas prey on gray whale calves and other mammals in most years. Endangered Southern Resident orcas, which prey on fish, have been seen in the region in multiple years. On occasion a pod of Offshore orcas, whose preferred prey are sharks, is observed in the region. While seen in MBNMS, none of the ecotypes are yet routinely detected and classified from passive acoustic monitoring (PAM) data. Continuous PAM from the center of MBNMS, through the Monterey Accelerated Research System (MARS), located at Smooth Ridge (36°42.75' N, 122°11.21' W) in Monterey Bay 30 km from shore and at about 900 m depth, provides the opportunity to advance knowledge of orcas in the region. MARS hosts a permanently deployed Ocean Sonics icListen HF digital broadband omnidirectional hydrophone (frequency range of 10 Hz to 100 kHz), whose signals are relayed back to shore in real time, 24/7 using the cabled ocean observatory. Since acoustic detections are rare, and manual annotation of sound recordings tedious, acoustic machine learning training data for species or ecotype detection and classification are hard to come by. We attempt to apply pre-trained community released machine learning models to the thousands of hours of recorded data to gain insights into the distribution of orcas in this habitat over time.

2. Application of Previous Models

Application of Google multi-species whale CNN model and OrcAI CNN model to resampled Pacific Sound MARS recordings yielded high confidence detection of orca calls in Monterey Bay. The Google multi-species whale model was trained by its authors on hundreds of recorded vocalizations of seven classes of whales (including orcas), and five vocalization variations. The OrcAI model was trained by its authors on hours of acoustic signals from Icelandic fish-eating orca recordings, with pulsed calls dominating the training signals. However, each model produced significant confusion in our Pacific Sound MARS recordings between orca calls, Pacific white-sided Dolphin calls (*Lagenorhynchus obliquidens*), and other detections, reducing the usefulness of these models to identify times that orcas were present in Monterey Bay.

3. Perch 2.0 Application

Here we report the results of our efforts to apply Perch 2.0 CNN foundation model to Pacific Sound archive recordings, using a small collection of labeled spectrograms of orca calls, dolphin calls, and other signals, and applying active learning (agile modeling) with a vector database in a system called Perch-Hoplite. Perch 2.0 is a pre-trained model for bioacoustics, trained in a supervised manner for off-the-shelf classification of thousands of multi-taxa vocalizations as well as strong embeddings for transfer learning. The model uses a convolutional architecture trained on mel-scaled log-spectrograms, along with a form of self-distillation and self-supervised loss with a goal of producing strong embeddings that are linearly separable to enable use in a range of bioacoustics tasks. Hoplite is a system for storing large volumes of embeddings to use for vector search and active learning workflow. We apply a small number of labeled spectrograms to transfer on fixed embeddings to enable one-shot retrieval through embedding vector search.

We compare our acoustic detections with visual sightings documented by the California Killer Whale Project and reports from vessels in Monterey Bay.

4. Conclusion

This work shows to the OCEANS community how a bioacoustics foundation model performs in enabling insights into marine mammal populations, and how it can be used to produce a custom classifier with a small amount of labeled data, which is efficient in researchers' time and in computational resources, and supports ecological and population assessment and protection.

5. References

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